**Oral Verification Toolkit**

**A Practical Guide for Confirming Intellectual Ownership in AI-Assisted Assessment**

**Version 1.0**

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**Citation**

Asghar, J. (2026). *Oral Verification Toolkit: A Practical Guide for Confirming Intellectual Ownership in AI-Assisted Assessment* (Version 1.0). AI Governance Framework Series. Higher Colleges of Technology.

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**About this Framework**

The Oral Verification Toolkit provides a structured approach for confirming intellectual ownership in AI-assisted assessment through educational dialogue. Rather than treating the verification discussion as an investigative response to suspected misconduct, the toolkit positions it as a proportionate assessment support strategy that strengthens confidence in authentic student learning. Building upon the principle of **Epistemic Responsibility** introduced in *From Assistance to Authorship*, the toolkit offers practical guidance for educators on when The conversation may be appropriate, how conversations can be conducted fairly, and how professional judgement may be supported through multiple forms of evidence. The toolkit complements the AI Governance Framework Series by operationalising one element of responsible assessment practice while preserving trust, transparency, and educational purpose.

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**Executive Summary**

The widespread availability of generative artificial intelligence has increased interest in oral verification as a means of confirming authentic student learning. However, oral verification is frequently misunderstood. In some institutions it is treated as an investigation triggered by suspicion of academic misconduct. In others it has become an informal conversation with little structure or consistency.

Neither approach fully reflects its educational purpose.

This toolkit presents the educational approach as an **assessment support strategy** rather than an investigative procedure. Its purpose is to provide educators with a structured, proportionate, and educationally defensible method for confirming intellectual ownership when additional evidence of authorship is required.

The toolkit complements *From Assistance to Authorship* by operationalising the principle of **Epistemic Responsibility**. It also supports the **Submission and Verification** stage of the *AI-Integrated Assessment Integrity Lifecycle*.

Importantly, the verification discussion should not be regarded as evidence that misconduct has occurred. In most cases it serves simply to strengthen confidence that submitted work represents genuine student learning.


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**Table of Contents**

## 1. Introduction

For generations, educators have confirmed student understanding through conversation. Viva examinations, dissertation defences, studio critiques, laboratory demonstrations, clinical discussions, and project presentations all require students to explain, justify, and defend their work orally.

Generative AI has renewed interest in these approaches because written submissions alone may no longer provide sufficient evidence of independent intellectual engagement.

This renewed interest should not be interpreted as a return to traditional oral examinations. Instead, it reflects a broader educational principle: assessment decisions are strengthened when educators can consider multiple forms of evidence regarding student learning.

Oral verification therefore occupies a distinctive role within AI-integrated assessment.

Its purpose is not to detect AI.

Its purpose is to confirm authorship.

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## 2. Purpose of Oral Verification

The toolkit has four objectives.

### Confirm intellectual ownership

To establish whether the student demonstrates ownership of the ideas, decisions, interpretations, and conclusions presented within the submitted work.

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### Support fair academic judgement

To provide additional evidence where written work alone leaves important educational questions unanswered.

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### Protect students

To ensure that concerns regarding AI use are addressed through educational dialogue rather than unsupported assumptions.

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### Promote confidence

To strengthen institutional confidence that assessment continues to evaluate meaningful learning despite increasing AI use.

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## 3. Guiding Principles

The toolkit is built upon six principles.

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### Educational before investigative

Oral verification is primarily an educational conversation.

Only exceptionally should it become part of formal academic integrity procedures.

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### Evidence-based

Verification should respond to identifiable educational reasons rather than intuition or writing style alone.

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### Proportionate

The level of questioning should reflect the educational significance of the concern.

Routine assessments rarely require extended oral verification.

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### Respectful

Students should experience verification as an opportunity to explain their thinking rather than defend themselves against accusation.

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### Consistent

Institutions should develop common approaches to questioning and decision-making.

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**Transparent**

Students should understand why verification is taking place and how the conversation contributes to assessment.

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### 4. When Oral Verification May Be Appropriate

Oral verification is not required for every assessment.

It may be appropriate when:

- substantial inconsistencies exist between drafts and final submission;
- writing quality changes unexpectedly without clear explanation;
- significant AI assistance has been disclosed;
- assessment design includes oral defence;
- supervisors require additional evidence of intellectual ownership;
- moderation identifies uncertainty regarding authorship.

In many cases, no verification will be necessary.

Assessment should proceed normally.

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### 5. When Oral Verification Is Usually Unnecessary

Verification should generally not be used simply because:

- AI tools were used responsibly;
- writing quality is high;
- language has improved;
- similarity reports are low;
- AI detectors suggest possible AI-generated text;
- an educator feels uncertain without supporting evidence.

The toolkit rejects routine verification based upon suspicion alone.

Professional judgement should remain evidence-based.

### 6. Preparing for Verification

Before meeting the student, the educator should clarify:

- Why is verification needed?
- Which learning outcomes require confirmation?
- Which aspects of the work require discussion?
- What evidence already exists?
- What outcome is sought?

Preparation ensures that verification remains focused upon educational judgement rather than general questioning.

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### 7. Structure of the Conversation

**Figure 1. Oral Verification Toolkit for AI-Assisted Assessment.** An operational framework illustrating the structure of an educationally focused oral verification discussion, together with illustrative questions, indicators of authentic understanding, potential areas requiring clarification, and principles for proportionate implementation.

A typical oral verification discussion should progress through four stages.

**Opening**

Explain the purpose.

Clarify that the discussion supports assessment rather than presumes misconduct.

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**Exploration**

Invite the student to explain:

- development of ideas;
- research decisions;
- analytical reasoning;
- methodological choices.

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**Clarification**

Discuss specific aspects requiring further explanation.

Questions should emerge naturally from the submitted work.

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**Closing**

Summarise the discussion.

Determine whether sufficient confidence now exists regarding intellectual ownership.

Where appropriate, explain any next steps.

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**8. Question Bank for Oral Verification**

The questions presented below are illustrative rather than prescriptive. Educators should adapt them according to the assessment, discipline, and learning outcomes under consideration.

Effective oral verification relies less on asking difficult questions than on asking appropriate ones. The objective is to understand the student's intellectual engagement with the work rather than to test memory or expose errors.

Questions should arise naturally from the submitted work and the intended learning outcomes.

The following question bank is organised according to the types of intellectual activity commonly demonstrated within higher education assessment.

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**A. Development of Ideas**

These questions explore how the student's thinking developed throughout the assessment.

Examples include:

- How did you first approach this assignment?
- What was your initial research question or central argument?
- How did your thinking change during the writing process?
- Which ideas did you eventually reject, and why?
- If you started this assignment again, what would you do differently?

These questions encourage students to describe their intellectual journey rather than reproduce factual knowledge.

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**B. Research and Evidence**

These questions examine the student's engagement with sources.

Examples include:

- Which sources most influenced your thinking?
- Why did you choose these sources rather than others?
- Which article or study did you find most difficult to interpret?

- Were there any conflicting viewpoints that you considered?
- How did you decide which evidence was strongest?

Students who have engaged meaningfully with the literature can usually explain these decisions comfortably.

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**C. Analysis and Interpretation**

These questions focus on disciplinary reasoning.

Examples include:

- How did you reach this conclusion?
- Why does this evidence support your interpretation?
- What alternative explanation did you consider?
- Which finding surprised you most?
- Which part of your analysis required the greatest judgement?

These questions explore reasoning rather than recall.

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**D. Methodology**

Where appropriate, students should be able to explain methodological decisions.

Examples include:

- Why did you choose this research method?
- What alternatives did you consider?
- What limitations does your approach have?
- If more time were available, what would you change?

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**E. Writing Process**

These questions examine how the submission developed.

Examples include:

- Which section was the most difficult to write?
- Which section changed the most during drafting?
- Did you reorganise your argument?
- Which feedback influenced your revisions?

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**F. AI Use**

These questions should be asked openly and without presumption.

Examples include:

- Where did AI assist you during this assessment?
- Which AI suggestions did you accept?
- Which suggestions did you reject?
- Why did you reject them?
- Which parts of the work represent entirely your own reasoning?

These questions reinforce reflection rather than confession.

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## 9. Indicators of Intellectual Ownership

Oral verification should consider multiple forms of evidence rather than relying upon isolated responses.

The following indicators may strengthen confidence that submitted work reflects authentic intellectual engagement.

**Strong Indicators**

The student:

- explains reasoning clearly;
- justifies analytical decisions;
- discusses rejected alternatives;
- acknowledges uncertainty appropriately;
- demonstrates familiarity with sources;

- connects ideas across different sections of the work;
- reflects on limitations;
- distinguishes between AI suggestions and personal decisions.

None of these indicators independently proves authorship.

Together they strengthen confidence.

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**10. Indicators Requiring Further Clarification**

The following observations should prompt further educational discussion rather than immediate assumptions regarding misconduct.

Examples include:

- inability to explain major conclusions;
- inconsistent explanations;
- unfamiliarity with cited evidence;
- confusion regarding methodological decisions;
- inability to distinguish personal reasoning from AI-generated suggestions;
- contradictory descriptions of the writing process.

These indicators require contextual interpretation.

They should never be treated as automatic evidence of academic misconduct.

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**11. Decision-Making Framework**

Following the verification discussion, educators should evaluate the available evidence holistically before determining the most appropriate educational outcome.

**Outcome 1**

**Confidence Confirmed**

The discussion provides sufficient evidence of intellectual ownership.

No further action.

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**Outcome 2**

**Minor Clarification**

Some aspects require additional explanation.

A short written clarification or supporting evidence is sufficient.

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**Outcome 3**

**Further Educational Review**

Additional discussion, supervision, or assessment evidence is appropriate before final judgement.

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**Outcome 4**

**Formal Academic Integrity Referral**

Only where substantial evidence indicates possible academic misconduct should institutional procedures be initiated.

The toolkit deliberately positions this as the least common outcome.

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## 12. Worked Examples

**Case Study 1**

**Appropriate AI Support**

Student:

Used AI to improve grammar after independently completing the assignment.

Verification outcome:

Student explains reasoning confidently.

AI contribution is consistent with disclosure.

**Decision**

Confidence confirmed.

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**Case Study 2**

**Extensive Drafting**

Student:

Disclosed AI-assisted drafting.

Verification demonstrates that the student independently developed arguments, rejected several AI suggestions, and revised the draft extensively.

**Decision**

Assessment proceeds normally.

Disclosure supported informed judgement.

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**Case Study 3**

**Significant Uncertainty**

Student cannot explain central interpretations, appears unfamiliar with cited evidence, and provides inconsistent explanations regarding the writing process.

**Decision**

Further educational review.

Institutional procedures considered only if additional evidence supports concern.

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## 13. Lecturer Verification Checklist

The following checklist supports consistent and proportionate implementation of oral verification. It is intended to guide professional judgement rather than prescribe rigid procedures.

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**Before the Conversation**

**Educational Purpose**

☐ Have I identified a clear educational reason for verification?

☐ Is verification proportionate to the circumstances?

☐ Have I reviewed the student's submission and any supporting evidence?

☐ Have I identified the specific learning outcomes requiring clarification?

☐ Has the discussion strengthened confidence in the student's intellectual ownership of the submitted work?

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**Student Information**

☐ Has the student been informed about the purpose of the discussion?

☐ Does the student understand that verification supports assessment rather than presumes misconduct?

☐ Has sufficient time been allocated for meaningful discussion?

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**During the Conversation**

**Student Understanding**

☐ Can the student explain how the work developed?

☐ Can the student justify major decisions?

☐ Can the student explain methodological choices?

☐ Can the student discuss limitations?

☐ Can the student distinguish their own reasoning from AI assistance where appropriate?

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**Professional Conduct**

☐ Were questions respectful?

☐ Did the discussion remain focused on educational evidence?

☐ Were assumptions avoided?

☐ Was the student given sufficient opportunity to explain?

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### After the Conversation

☐ Does the available evidence support confidence in intellectual ownership?

☐ Is additional clarification required?

☐ Should assessment proceed normally?

☐ Is further educational review appropriate?

☐ Is formal academic integrity referral genuinely justified?

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## 14. Oral Verification Record

Institutions may adapt the following template for internal use.

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### Student Information

Student Name

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Student ID

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Module

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Assessment

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Date

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Verifier

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### Duration of discussion

____ **minutes**

**Reason for Verification**

☐ Routine assessment design

☐ Clarification requested

☐ Significant AI disclosure

☐ Moderation recommendation

☐ Other

**Discussion Summary**

**Outcome**

☐ Confidence confirmed

☐ Minor clarification required

☐ Further educational review

☐ Academic integrity referral

**Comments**

**15. Student Information Sheet**

Students should understand the educational purpose of oral verification before participating.

The following statement may be provided before the discussion.

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**What is Oral Verification?**

Oral verification is a short academic discussion designed to help educators understand how you developed your work.

It is **not** an examination.

It is **not** an accusation of academic misconduct.

It is an opportunity for you to explain your thinking, describe your learning process, and demonstrate ownership of your work.

You may be asked to discuss:

- how your ideas developed;
- why you made particular decisions;
- how you interpreted evidence;
- where AI assisted you;
- which decisions remained your own.

Most conversations last between 10 and 20 minutes depending on the assessment.

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**16. Frequently Asked Questions**

**Does oral verification mean I have done something wrong?**

No.

Many verification conversations form part of normal assessment practice or are used to clarify aspects of submitted work.

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**Will I be asked to remember every reference?**

No.

Verification explores understanding and intellectual ownership rather than factual recall.

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**What if I used AI appropriately?**

Appropriate AI use should not disadvantage you.

Verification simply helps educators understand how AI contributed to your work.

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**Can oral verification change my mark?**

Verification contributes additional evidence supporting academic judgement.

Marks continue to be awarded according to achievement of learning outcomes and institutional regulations.

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**Can I prepare?**

Yes.

Review your work, reflect on your writing process, and be ready to explain your reasoning.

Preparation is entirely appropriate.

You are not expected to remember every detail of your assignment. The purpose of the discussion is to understand your reasoning and learning process rather than to test memory.

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**17. Institutional Implementation**

Oral verification is most effective when embedded within assessment practice rather than reserved exclusively for academic integrity investigations.

Institutions should therefore:

- provide staff development;

- establish common questioning principles;
- promote consistency across programmes;
- develop proportionate verification procedures;
- avoid unnecessary administrative burden;
- review implementation periodically.
- integrate verification guidance within assessment design rather than treating it as a standalone procedure.

Verification should support educational quality rather than expand institutional bureaucracy.

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### 18. Relationship with the Companion Framework Suite

The Oral Verification Toolkit operationalises **Epistemic Responsibility**, one of the three foundational principles established in *From Assistance to Authorship*.

Within the **AI-Integrated Assessment Integrity Lifecycle**, the toolkit supports:

| Framework | Contribution |
|---|---|
| From Assistance to Authorship | Conceptual foundation |
| AI-Integrated Assessment Integrity Lifecycle | Assessment process |
| AI Disclosure Framework | Transparency |
| Assessment Authenticity Checklist | Assessment design |
| AI Risk-Level Matrix | Educational risk evaluation |
| Institutional AI Governance Guide | Institution-wide implementation |

Together, these resources strengthen confidence in authentic student learning without relying primarily on AI detection technologies.

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### 19. Limitations

Oral verification is not a substitute for good assessment design.

Poorly designed assessments cannot be made authentic simply by adding post-submission interviews.

Similarly, verification should not become routine for every assessment, nor should it function as an indirect AI detection process.

The toolkit supports educational judgement. It cannot eliminate uncertainty in every case.

Professional expertise, disciplinary expectations, and institutional policy remain essential.

This toolkit is conceptual and practice-informed. It has not yet undergone formal empirical validation as a standardised verification instrument.

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**20. Conclusion**

Generative AI has renewed interest in oral verification, but its educational value extends beyond concerns about technology.

Effective educators have always sought evidence that students understand, justify, and take responsibility for their work.

The Oral Verification Toolkit formalises this longstanding educational practice within an AI-enabled assessment environment.

Rather than positioning oral verification as an investigative response to suspected misconduct, the toolkit reframes it as an opportunity to confirm intellectual ownership, strengthen confidence in assessment decisions, and promote meaningful dialogue between students and educators.

When implemented proportionately and respectfully, oral verification supports assessment integrity while preserving trust, fairness, and educational purpose.

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**Framework Status**

**Framework type:** Operational assessment support framework

**Development status:** Conceptual and practice-informed

**Empirical status:** This toolkit is conceptual and practice-informed and has not yet undergone formal empirical validation as a standardised verification instrument.

**Primary users**

- Lecturers
- Supervisors
- Dissertation advisors
- Programme leaders
- External examiners
- Academic integrity officers
- Quality assurance teams

**Companion frameworks**

- *From Assistance to Authorship*
- *AI-Integrated Assessment Integrity Lifecycle*
- *AI Disclosure Framework*
- *Assessment Authenticity Checklist*
- *AI Risk-Level Matrix*
- *Institutional AI Governance Guide for Assessment Integrity*

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### 21. Version History

| Version | Date | Description |
|---|---|---|
| 1.0 | July 2026 | Initial public release |